Draft - expert review pending

Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

Topic 1.5 - The critical thinker, and the teacher as one

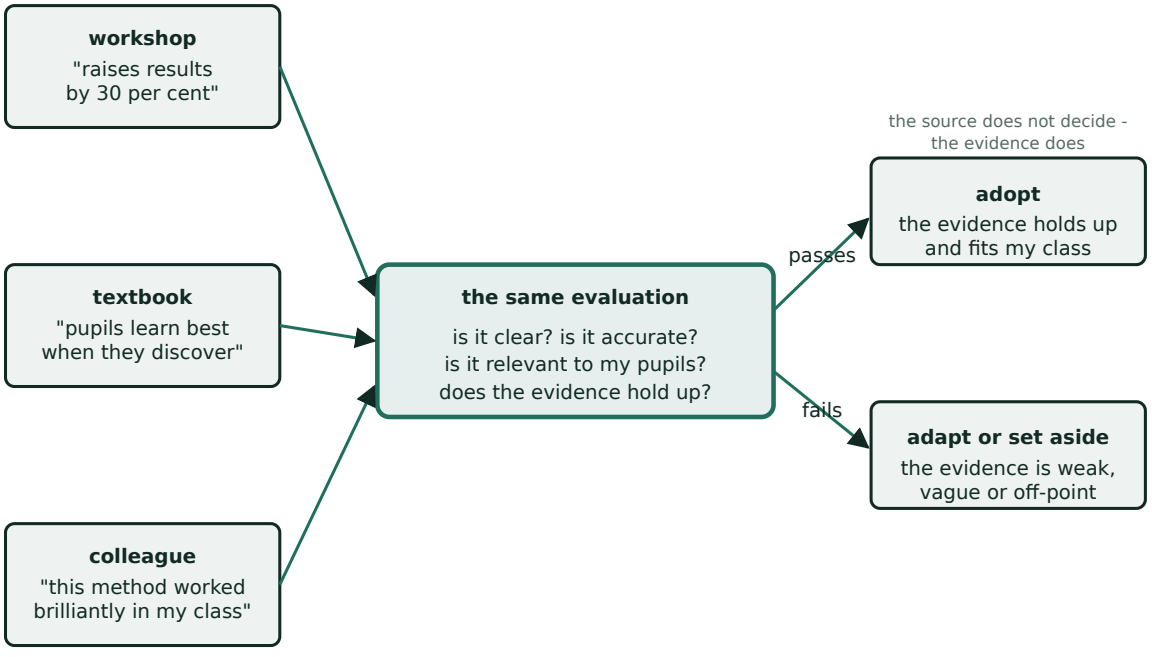
A real classroom situation

A workshop trainer tells a group of teachers in Sukkur that a new reading method "raises results by 30 per cent". Three teachers hear the claim. The first accepts it and plans to adopt the method. The second dismisses it because "these workshops never understand our classrooms". The third asks, "Thirty per cent of what, measured how, compared with which schools, over how long?" None of the three is being rude. But only one of them is treating the claim as something to examine rather than simply to accept or reject.

Critical thinker	What that looks like in a classroom	The opposite
open to evidence	the data shows my method is not working - I will change it	I have always done it this way, so it must be right
fair to opposing views	let me hear the strongest version of the other side first	I only listen to people who already agree with me
precise in claims	punctuation errors fell by a quarter over one term	results will improve a lot next year
willing to say I do not know	I have no evidence either way - let us look first	I am sure I am right even though I have not checked
questions before deciding	what is the evidence and does it fit my pupils	I will adopt it because the speaker sounded confident
revises with new facts	the new assessment changes what I thought I knew	I ignore anything that does not fit my first view

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This topic describes the habits that make someone a critical thinker and shows what those habits look like in a teacher's working day.

Explanation

Characteristics of a critical thinker

A critical thinker is not a different kind of person. They are someone who has made certain habits routine. Bassham et al. (2010) describe them as a set of paired opposites: a critical thinker leans toward the first in each pair and away from the second.

- **Open to evidence** rather than wedded to their first view. When new facts arrive, they adjust.
- **Fair to opposing views** rather than dismissive. They consider the strongest version of the other side, not a weakened one.
- **Precise rather than vague** in the claims they make and accept. "Results improved" is less useful than "punctuation errors fell by a quarter over one term".
- **Willing to say "I don't know"** rather than guessing or bluffing. In a staffroom this sounds like, "I have no evidence either way - let us look before we decide."

These are habits, not talents. A trainee who is unsure of herself can still ask, "What is the evidence for that?" - and that question is the move that matters.

Teachers as critical thinkers

For a teacher, critical thinking is not an abstract skill. It shows up in three ordinary situations.

Evaluating a workshop or training claim. Trainers and resource sellers make strong claims. A critical-thinking teacher treats each claim as something to examine: *What is the evidence? Is it relevant to my pupils' age and context? Has it been tested in a setting like mine?* This is not

cynicism; it is the professional habit of adopting only what is well supported.

Reading a textbook or guide critically. A textbook is not wrong by definition, but it is also not above question. A teacher who asks, "Does this example fit my pupils? Is this the only way to teach this idea?" is thinking critically about the material rather than following it mechanically.

Handling claims from colleagues. A head teacher's announcement, a senior colleague's advice, a parent's expectation - each may be right, but none is right only because of who said it. A critical-thinking teacher respects the person and still asks whether the reasoning holds.

> **Common misconception.** Many trainees arrive believing that "critical thinking is a personality you have or lack rather than a set of standards you apply". The opposite is true. The characteristics of a critical thinker are habits you can practise, and this unit has given you the standards to practise them with. You do not need to become a different person; you need to make a few questions routine.

Activity: Evaluate three sources of a claim

Work in small groups. About 20 minutes.

The claim: **"Mind-mapping improves pupils' writing."** It reaches a teacher from three sources at the same time: a workshop handout, a page in the textbook, and a senior colleague who says it worked in her class.

1. For each source, write one question a critical-thinking teacher would ask before adopting the idea.

2. As a group, decide which source you would trust most and give one reason drawn from the characteristics of a critical thinker (not "because the person is senior").
3. Share your decision with another group and compare reasons.

Check your understanding

1. **Remember** Name three characteristics of a critical thinker.

2. **Understand** Explain why "willing to say I don't know" is a characteristic of a critical thinker rather than a weakness.

3. **Apply** A senior teacher says, "Set less homework; my pupils always do well." Which characteristic of a critical thinker would lead you to ask for evidence, and what question would you ask?

Summary

The characteristics of a critical thinker - open to evidence, fair to opposing views, precise in claims, willing to say "I don't know" - are habits, not talents. For a teacher they show up in the ordinary work of evaluating workshop claims, reading textbooks critically and handling colleagues' advice on its merits.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can name and explain at least three characteristics of a critical thinker.
- [ ] I can recognise when I am accepting or rejecting a claim for the wrong reason (the source rather than the evidence).
- [ ] I can ask an evidence-based question of a claim I meet in a workshop, a textbook or a staffroom.

Try this at your practicum school

At your next training or staff meeting, write down one claim you hear. Then write the one question a critical-thinking teacher would ask before adopting it. If you feel able, ask the question.

Summative task

Take this single piece of staffroom reasoning: **"We should not change how we teach fractions; the way we learned them ourselves worked fine, and our pupils always pass the fraction items in the exam." ** Write a short paragraph (100-140 words) that (a) evaluates the reasoning against *two* of the critical-thinking standards from Topic 1.2, (b) names the barrier from Topic 1.3 it most shows, and (c) justifies your choice of barrier with a specific piece of the reasoning.

This task draws Topics 1.2, 1.3 and 1.5 together.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	Levels
Standards applied	0-2: two standards named and applied correctly to the reasoning / one or misapplied / none.

Criterion	Levels
Barrier identified	0-3: barrier named correctly and justified with specific reasoning / named but weakly justified / wrong. (**Analyze**: cites a specific piece of the reasoning as evidence for the barrier.)
Clarity	0-2: paragraph coherent and within word band / unclear or over length.

Further reading

Bassham, G., Irwin, W., Nardone, H., & Wallace, J. M. (2010). *Critical thinking: A student's introduction* (4th ed.). McGraw-Hill. Chapter 1 returns to the habits and characteristics of a critical thinker drawn together in this topic.

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